

LEC17 - Health and Care

Health

Disease: An objective biological problem

Illness: The personal experience of being unwell, which is often socially and culturally conditioned

Smoking and SES

- Low SES populations are more likely to smoke daily, smoke more, and be less likely to quit
 - More prevalent in working-class workplaces
 - More embedded in daily routines (smoke breaks)
 - Homes are more smoker-friendly
 - Peer smoking means more exposure to social norms that encourage smoking
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Vaping

- Marketed to young people
- Sleek designs, compatible with modern tech, flavours, young people in ads

EVALI: E-cigarette or Vaping product use-Associated Lung Injury

- Modified devices or substances not designed by manufacturer
 - THC, off market liquids
 - Dozens of deaths, thousands of injuries
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Alcohol

- Consumed by nearly 80% of population
- Alcohol-related costs like hospital stays are nearly \$15 billion a year

SES Paradox

- High SES → More drinking
- Low SES → More harm
- Caused by more conflating factors like stress, poor diet, beverage choices, and frequency of binge drinking

Class Inequality

Stress

- Exposure to difficult living conditions
- Money problems, marital problems, longer work hours, less autonomy
- Inability to cope, take breaks, relieve stress
- Linked to mental health, high BP, cancer, and substance use
- Telomere length (measure of cell aging) shorter for those living in disadvantage

Development

- Prenatal exposure
- Poor nutrition, maternal smoking, lack of exercise
- Suboptimal fetal development with lifelong consequences

Education

- Less knowledge about healthy lifestyles
- Less knowledge about healthy diet

Access

- Inferior medical services
 - Limited access to other medical treatment
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Culture

- Ideas about causes and mechanism of illness heavily influenced by culture
 - Cultural background predictor of cancer screening
 - Perceptions about chemical / unnatural origins of prescriptions are influenced by culture
 - Religious ideas and treatment are influenced by culture
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Health Care

Public Health System

- Government run programs that ensure access to clean drinking water, basic sewage and sanitation, and inoculation

Health Care System

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- A nation's clinics, hospitals, and other facilities for ensuring health and treating illness
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Obesity

- Thinness as a health and social ideal
- Perpetuated by media, weight loss industry, fashion industry, government policy, and medical profession
 - Thin means healthy, beautiful, and responsible
 - Obese means unhealthy, unattractive, and lazy
 - None of these ideas can be generalized for any person

Factors

- Individual
 - Less physical activity
 - Less time outdoors
 - More sedentary
 - Less activity for children
 - Genetic factors (40% - 70%), but not entirely predictive of rapid increase
 - Poor dietary choices
- Environmental
 - SES and class-based food preferences (inexpensive and filling vs light and fresh)
 - Widespread use of high fructose corn syrup in processed foods
 - Greater food consumption through social patterns like longer work weeks, constant availability of cheap food options
 - Tech like microwaves that encourage quick food prep
 - Less physical education in schools